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The Wolof of Senegambia

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CHIEFTAINSHIP AND GOVERNMENT IN THE WOLOF STATES • FRIENDSHIP • JOKING RELATIONSHIPS • POLITICAL SYSTEM

Among the Wolof the relationship is expressed in terms of *jam* (slave) and *b[unknown]r[unknown]m* (master), a father's sister's child will be *jam*, a mother's brother's child *b[unknown]r[unknown]m*. In clan relationships, the Njai are the *b[unknown]r[unknown]m* of the Gei, the Gei *b[unknown]r[unknown]m* of the Seka, the Seka *b[unknown]r[unknown]m* of the Job, and so on. On ceremonial occasions the *jam* come to help their *b[unknown]r[unknown]m*, and are rewarded for their services. At circumcision *jam* stay with their *b[unknown]r[unknown]m* during the period of seclusion, and are given clothing. When a woman is married her *jam*¹⁶ perform dances for her, carry her loads to her husband's compound, and accompany her on ceremonial visits.

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If a person happens to perform certain actions in the presence of one with whom he has a joking relationship, he commits *chalit*, and the *b[unknown]r[unknown]m* or *jam* has the right to take some of his property or demand a gift. Serious penalties can be imposed; if a chief were to commit *chalit* a cow might be demanded. Such actions are: failing to call a person to join in eating; leaving something behind after eating; cutting a finger when using a knife.

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FRIENDSHIP

Among the Wolof there are institutionalized friendships between members of the same sex, but especially between men. Such friendships are often formed in the circumcision shed or at school. The two friends tell each other their secrets, things they would not even tell their parents, exchange garments¹⁷—a sign of high favour—and help each other in times of trouble. A true friend should be prepared to give his aid even if it means breaking the law. It is not expected that one should have many friends of this nature.¹⁸

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Friendships

POLITICAL SYSTEM

The Wolof developed an elaborate system of government in which a “noble” class dominated the country, and elected rulers whose functions were to ensure the power of the state by leadership in war and to bring prosperity through the exercise of magical powers.

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The religious wars of the last century between Muslims and pagans brought about the downfall of the old Wolof system, and this process was completed with the establishment of the British and French systems of government, but even at the present day one sometimes finds important survivals,¹⁹ and attitudes and actions reminiscent of old times are occasionally to be observed.

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CHIEFTAINSHIP AND GOVERNMENT IN THE WOLOF STATES

The earliest descriptions available of the Wolof chiefs occur in the writings of Cada Mosto (1455):—²⁰

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“The kingdom [of Senega] is not hereditary, but commonly three or four lords (of which there are many in the country) chuse a king to their own liking, (yet always of noble parentage) who reigns as long as he pleases them. They often dethrone their kings by force, and the kings many times render themselves so powerful, as to stand on their defence.... This king has no certain revenues, but the lords of the country, to court his favour, make him presents every year of horses... and other beasts, such ■⁵⁶ as cows and goats; also pulse, millet, and such like things. This king likewise lives by robberies, and forcing some of his subjects and those of neighbouring provinces into slavery; part whereof he employs in cultivating the lands assigned him, and sells the rest to the Azanaghi and Arabian merchants, who trade here with horses, and other things, as well as to the Christians, since Trade has been opened between them.

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¹⁶ Real *jam* (descendants of household slaves) also take part in such ceremonies.

¹⁷ Witches, sorcerers, etc., could work evil with sweat-stained garments.

¹⁸ The **Wolof** philosopher K[unknown]he stated: "One sometimes has *one* friend, one never has several", and gave as an example the tale of Mafal who, it seemed, had innumerable friends. To test them he went one night and knocked at the door of each, saying: "I am in great trouble. I have just killed the king's son." All drove him away in horror except one, who said, "Let us flee together. I will help you to safety", and was prepared to leave the bride he had just married and set out immediately (quoted by Béranger-Féraud).

¹⁹ Ames, for instance, has drawn attention to the fact that in Kahone the present chief of the canton is a descendant of the *Bur Salum* and that there are several old men living there who still hold traditional offices. (Personal communication, 1951.)

²⁰ Astley, 1745, vol. I, p. 581.

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